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Tech, Inequality, and the Transformation of Seattle

We may have to destroy our city in order to save it.

— Emmett Watson, *Seattle Post-Intelligencer*, 1978¹

For more than five decades from the 1940s, the columnist Emmett Watson served as the conscience of Seattle as his city transformed beyond recognition. Born in 1918 near the Duwamish River, Watson first lived in a house with no running water, a mile northwest of the airfield where William E. Boeing was building his first airplanes.² “Nobody ever heard of Boeing in those days,” Watson later wrote, but soon enough they had; for much of his life, Seattle rose and fell on Boeing’s wings.³ In his senior years, the city changed again. By 2001, when Watson died, the city had become a flourishing technology (tech) hub. Seattle was home to two of the three richest billionaires in the world, Bill Gates and Paul Allen of Microsoft, and was on its way to seeing Jeff Bezos, the founder of Amazon, become wealthier still.⁴

“If there is one thing that splits Seattle wide open with controversy,” Watson wrote in 1957, “it’s our unholy urge toward progress and more progress.”⁵ The columnist stoked that controversy, counterbalancing city boosters who advocated growth with a fictional, satirical nonprofit called “Lesser Seattle, Inc.” As national writers declared Seattle to be the most livable city in the nation from the 1970s on, Watson inveighed against arriving residents, using intentionally blunt rhetoric and suggesting that the city publicize its infamous rain.⁶ After the tech boom proved too potent for Lesser Seattle’s defenses, he lamented that “computer nerds—or geeks, if you prefer—are not substantial citizens,” that they seemed to ignore civic matters, and that they refused to share their prosperity.⁷ For some readers, Watson was a prophet. For others, he was narrow-minded and exclusionary, not to mention wrong.⁸

What did growth truly mean? What was progress? By 2026, Microsoft and Amazon had grown Seattle into a wealthy, innovative, globally connected place, offering rare prospects for success.⁹ Yet growth had also turned Seattle into a city where teachers, firefighters, and machinists could barely support a family, let alone buy a home.¹⁰ Colossal riches on the one hand, pervasive inequality on the other: columnist Danny Westneat called the phenomenon a “prosperity bomb.”¹¹ So, had the tech boom opened opportunity, or limited it? Had it created a new middle class, or merely made city life untenable for the old one? As Mayor Katie Wilson—a socialist elected on an affordability agenda—took office,

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was the strain on economic inclusion an unavoidable result of innovation, destined to worsen as the artificial intelligence (AI) revolution took hold? Or a challenge that different policies could meet?

New York, Someday

It was God, or one of his gifted aesthetic subcontractors, who gave us the water, the trees, the coolness, the gentleness, the hills and mountains, the sense of openness and space. Nothing we have done has improved on any of these.

— Emmett Watson, *Seattle Times*, 1991¹²

Seattle had long been a town where people came to build their fortunes. (See **Exhibit 1** for population statistics.) Cradled by mountain ranges and with Mount Rainier towering at the southeast horizon, the land between saltwater Puget Sound to the west and freshwater Lake Washington to the east had been home to Indigenous families for millennia before White settlers arrived in 1851.¹³ The first White settlement poked into the Sound, and its founders signaled their ambitions for the village by calling it first New York, then New York Alki, “Alki” being the Chinook word for “someday” or “eventually.”¹⁴ By 1853, however, most of the settlers had moved around Elliott Bay to a site with far better prospects as a port. This they named Seattle, after Sealth, the seemingly acquiescent chief of the local Suquamish and Duwamish tribes.¹⁵

Seattle initially grew slowly, with an early economy that depended on lumber cut from the endless forests around town.¹⁶ But after the Northern Pacific Railway connected the city to the intercontinental rail network in 1884, it boomed as a trade hub, adding an estimated 1,000 residents per month by early 1889, the year that the Great Seattle Fire destroyed the makeshift downtown and set the stage for more orderly development.¹⁷ Seattle’s port soon became the gateway both to Alaska, where a gold rush drew prospectors by the thousands after 1897, and to the Pacific Ocean.¹⁸ During World War I, Seattle served as a shipbuilding center; one local shipbuilding company, Skinner & Eddy, hired 13,000 workers, earned \$100 million in federal contracts, and perfected its processes to such an extent that it could build an 8,800-ton cargo ship in just 55 working days.¹⁹

Once the war ended, though, defense spending flatlined and the city struggled, in a pattern that would become familiar over the half century to come. Skinner & Eddy closed its plant in 1923, and in 1931 the empty shipyard became an encampment for the homeless, one of several city Hoovervilles—shanty towns named ironically after President Herbert Hoover—that sprawled throughout the Great Depression.²⁰ “There were fewer wage earners in the entire Seattle-Tacoma area in 1940 than there had been inside Seattle in 1920,” historian Roger Sale noted. The local economy changed little in those two decades, but with the coming of another world war, that soon changed.²¹

Manufacturing Seattle

Boeing Boom

I’m glad I worked for Boeing once, because this kind of puts the “Made in Seattle” stamp on me. [. . .] When I first arrived at Boeing [in 1939], they gave me a file. From four o’ clock to midnight all I did was file. Pieces of aluminum—hundreds of them, all shapes—were cut from a template by a band saw. The saw left the aluminum with a “burr” which was jagged and sharp. My job was to file off the burr. Eight hours a night. Four hundred and eighty minutes. It was dreadful, mind-numbing work. A few times I deliberately cut a finger on this burr. The idea was that you could get a half-hour break to visit the infirmary. That’s how awful it was.

— Emmett Watson, *Digressions of a Native Son*, 1982²²

Boeing takes off Boeing, too, was seeded from the trees of Washington state. In 1902, a wealthy Yale dropout named William E. Boeing journeyed across the country to found a lumber company in Hoquiam, about 100 miles southwest of Seattle.²³ In 1910, having since moved to Seattle, Boeing saw a plane fly for the first time, and six years after that, he first flew a seaplane made by his own company, the B&W.²⁴ Operating from a little factory known as the Red Barn, south of downtown, the Boeing Airplane Company had a rocky first few years, using its founder's wood to make frames and doing what business it could supplying fighter aircraft to the U.S. military and transport planes to the Post Office.²⁵ The company was a key player in the nascent aviation industry, especially for the few years—1929 to 1934—that regulators allowed it to merge with engine maker Pratt & Whitney, yet flying remained a niche enough activity that it stayed small for its first two decades.²⁶ In Seattle, though, aviation had an outsized impact: Boeing had only 900 employees in 1928, but it was already the largest industrial employer in the area.²⁷

A series of brave bets turned Boeing into an engineering and manufacturing colossus. It placed the first in 1934, staking its future on designing a heavy bomber for the U.S. military, despite the common belief that such an aircraft was impractical.²⁸ After 1941, when the U.S. entered World War II, Boeing's B-17 "Flying Fortress" proved otherwise, enabling the destruction of German industry and clearing the skies for the invasion of Europe; the even larger B-29 "Superfortress" played a similar role over Japan.²⁹ The B-17 and B-29 transformed Boeing. In 1944, the company earned \$600 million in sales, or about the same as all of Washington's manufacturers in 1939.³⁰ Not every B-17 or B-29 was made in or near Seattle, but mass production also propelled the city, which meanwhile saw a shipbuilding revival.³¹ Seattle workers built 6,981 B-17s at a rate of up to 16 per day at Boeing's Plant Two, situated on land the company had bought for \$1 from residents anxious that it should not decamp for California.³² More than 1,100 B-29s emerged from a former Navy plant in the nearby mining town of Renton, whose population increased tenfold in just a few years.³³ One in six residents of booming King County, which included both Seattle and Renton, was among Boeing's 50,000 local employees by the end of the war.³⁴

Boeing continued to depend on military contracts as World War turned to Cold War, but it placed its second set of bets on the belief that it could use the engineering expertise it gained developing the B-47 and B-52 jet bombers to inaugurate the commercial, civilian jet age before other companies could compete.³⁵ In the 1950s, Boeing President William Allen invested almost all of the company's spare capital into the Dash-80 prototype and the 707 production plane, despite initial safety concerns and a lack of launch customers; in time, Renton workers built more than 1,000 707s from 1958 to 1991, 1,832 727s between 1962 and 1984, and, after 1967, more than 10,000 737s.³⁶ Making the 747 jumbo jet, a plane so complex that it had 6 million parts and 171 miles of wiring, required the largest factory building in the world to enable assembly; refusing to base production elsewhere, Boeing flattened hills and cleared forests at Everett, 40 miles north of Seattle, to create a facility that was easily larger than Disneyland.³⁷

Jet City As Boeing soared, it climbed into an uneasy relationship with Seattle. "Everybody either worked for Boeing, their parents worked for Boeing, or they knew someone who worked for Boeing," one historian said.³⁸ Seattle became known as "Jet City," and its basketball team was named the SuperSonics after a Boeing prototype, the Super Sonic Transport (SST).³⁹ Giving more to charity than any other regional enterprise, Boeing also catalyzed other industries statewide, including a construction sector building worker housing and an aluminum sector that that used power from Columbia River dams to control 40% of U.S. smelting capacity, much of it destined for Boeing's planes.⁴⁰ Almost from its birth, Boeing sought to turn the University of Washington (UW) into an engineering hub: UW graduates dominated its engineering staff, managed its major projects, and tested its planes in campus wind tunnels that it had paid for.⁴¹ Each Boeing job supported at least two more

locally.⁴² Senator Henry M. Jackson might have been dubbed “the Senator from Boeing” for his efforts to keep federal contracts flowing to the company, but the nickname cost him nothing at the ballot box.⁴³

Yet Boeing itself seemed ambivalent about its role. For decades, it accepted its identity as a Seattle company and took decisions accordingly. “We try to do our best to be good citizens in the community,” Allen said in the early 1950s, adding, “we believe in this part of the world and want to stay here and live here and succeed here.”⁴⁴ Allen consistently declined requests to move civilian plants to Southern California or elsewhere, and he insisted that the 747 would be made in Everett, despite the city ranking far down a list of possible options prepared by subordinates.⁴⁵ Yet Allen refused to let Boeing give the impression that Seattle was a company town, even if that impression was inevitably left anyway. The company built no skyscraper downtown, and if its nondescript headquarters were within city limits, its plants were placed outside them.⁴⁶ Local officials gave the company what it needed, but its lobbying was quiet, its power far from absolute.⁴⁷ “Most of even the well-informed people in Seattle,” Sale wrote, “would not be able to give the names of Boeing’s major executives, or to recognize them by sight.”⁴⁸

Even so, Boeing’s success was the inescapable foundation for affluence in the Seattle metropolitan area in the 1950s and 1960s. Although Boeing had a testy relationship with union leaders, and Allen in particular had a reputation for despising organized labor, its bargaining agreements with Local Lodge 751 of the International Association of Machinists (IAM) meant that even uneducated workers could join the company and enjoy prosperity.⁴⁹ Outside of Boeing, the Teamsters organized the rest of Seattle’s workers until it was one of the most unionized cities in the U.S., with its workers usually enjoying substantial financial security.⁵⁰ Members of both unions felt themselves to be middle class, and union leaders promoted a vision of suburban living complete with affordable family homes and cars on the driveway, ready for freeway commutes.⁵¹ According to the 1960 census, 67% of residents in the Seattle area lived in owner-occupied homes, of which the median was worth \$13,600.⁵² Renters paid a median \$76 per month.⁵³ A Boeing machinist earned \$3.09 per hour, giving him an income roughly a third higher than the median male in Washington state, who earned \$4,626 per year.⁵⁴

“Respectable Seattle was, and sedate,” journalist Murray Morgan reflected, “a city of high wages [. . .] and of pleasant homes; a regional metropolis which considered itself to be without slums; a city of big wooden houses and wide green lawns, of parks and lakes and hills and trees, but a city still believing that growth would mean greatness. Seattle did not consider itself great, yet.”⁵⁵ It was already apparent that growth had downsides: until the 1960s, sewage was dumped from areas with inadequate infrastructure into Lake Washington and Puget Sound, requiring a cleanup effort, and the sprawl of suburbia caused downtown areas to decline so far that city leaders tried to spark a revival by staging the World’s Fair in 1962, endowing the skyline with the Space Needle and a Monorail.⁵⁶ So long as Boeing kept growing, few complained.

Boeing Bust

Haven't we learned anything from the Boeing debacle? Isn't it time we thought of ourselves as a many-industry town, a city that has learned how perilous it is to depend, entirely, on one Big Daddy?

— Emmett Watson, *Seattle Post-Intelligencer*, 1971⁵⁷

An alarming article in Harper's (or was it the Atlantic?) called us "America's most livable city." [. . .] Paradise beckoned to mosquito-bitten Midwesterners, those pushy Easterners, and we were, in a phrase of the day, becoming "Californicated." "We've got to keep them out!" I snapped to a C[hamber] of C[ommerce] official. "Watkins," he said, patiently, "you have a no-growth mentality." "You mean I've stopped growing mentally?" I asked. "That happened a long time ago," he replied. "What I mean is, you are anti-progress. Progress: more

people, bigger buildings, high-rises, large developments. What made America great." That did it. It is time to staff the parapets, ladies and gentlemen – be you Lesser Seattleites or not.

– Emmett Watson, *Seattle Post-Intelligencer*, 1977⁵⁸

Boeing crashes By 1967, Boeing employed 148,000 people across the Seattle region. One in five salaries earned in King County was paid by the company, and it accounted for 61% of all manufacturing jobs in the wider area.⁵⁹ Boasting a bulging order book—international air travel was growing at 15% annually, and domestic travel was on the rise—the company doubled its local payroll from 1965 to 1968.⁶⁰ But the boom had been a gamble. Boeing had borrowed \$1 billion to fund the development of the 747, which first emerged from its Everett factory in September 1968, and the SST had been troubled.⁶¹ U.S. airlines had already paid deposits for the planes they needed, and new orders were falling.⁶² Rapid hiring had caused productivity to drop, meaning that profits were slim on any aircraft it sold.⁶³ Military contracts were slowing as the U.S. government sought to end the war in Vietnam; soon Congress would cancel funding for the SST.⁶⁴ Late in 1969, the U.S. entered a recession.⁶⁵

Seattle was lastingly scarred by the “Boeing Bust” that followed. From 1968 to 1970, Boeing had negative cash flow and was at serious risk of bankruptcy.⁶⁶ Allen’s successor, T. A. Wilson, fired 25,000 workers in 1969, 41,000 in 1970, and 22,000 in 1971.⁶⁷ The company closed 10 million square feet of facilities and shut an entire 737 factory.⁶⁸ By 1971, Seattle area unemployment hit 17%, the worst rate in the U.S., and a year later, aerospace was contributing less than half what it had to the local economy four years earlier.⁶⁹ All around the oldest Boeing plants, workers defaulted on their mortgages; the Federal Housing Authority, which provided cheap financing to mostly White homeowners, was briefly the largest landowner in town.⁷⁰ The *Economist* called Seattle the “City of Despair.”⁷¹ On April 16, 1971, two real estate agents taking satirical aim at such sentiments put the words “Will the last person leaving SEATTLE – Turn out the lights” on a billboard near the airport.⁷² (See **Exhibit 2.**) City councilors, among other officials, began to talk of building a more diversified local economy.⁷³

Professional Seattle By the time Seattle began to boom again, around the end of the decade, it had changed. Boeing survived, largely due to unexpectedly strong sales of its 727 and an export market that grew drastically despite volatile oil prices.⁷⁴ It was exactly that export market that pointed to the context of Seattle’s transformation. The 1970s were a decade of rampant globalization, as economies worldwide weaved together as never before.⁷⁵ In the U.S., the consequent structural dislocation was felt in stubborn unemployment, high inflation, and weak growth, a trifecta dubbed stagflation. In the process, as historian Charles S. Maier interpreted the shift, a U.S. “empire of production” based on manufacturing dominance after World War II turned into an “empire of consumption,” as Americans bought products increasingly made overseas and reoriented their own economy around services.⁷⁶ “Seattle,” scholar Andrew Hedden later added, “served as a beachhead for these transformations.”⁷⁷

During the 1970s, Seattle recast itself as a city of professionals. Unemployment remained higher than the national average and employment growth was little better than average, but almost all the jobs created in the area—over 91%—were created in the service sector.⁷⁸ Office construction soared, and, by 1980, “nearly two out of three of the city’s residents worked managerial, professional, technical, or administrative white-collar jobs.”⁷⁹ Wages shot up, with only San Francisco residents enjoying a higher income.⁸⁰ As working class families moved out, new arrivals took advantage of relatively cheap housing; nearly two thirds of newcomers were under the age of 30.⁸¹ In 1970, more Seattleites had lacked a high school education than had been to college; a decade later, the reverse was true.⁸² As places like Detroit, New York, and Los Angeles endured political, economic, and social difficulties, Seattle felt “eminently civilized,” said *Harper’s* magazine, which declared it to be “America’s most livable city” in 1975.⁸³ In 1977, *Time* said that Seattle had “almost none of the hassles and almost all of

the amenities of many bigger American cities.”⁸⁴ Watson described such press as “a knockout propaganda blow.”⁸⁵

Digital Seattle

Microsoft

Worst of all, [the software nerd] is cheap. When he gets his millions, he buys a Maserati or a Mercedes [. . .]. Then he stops contributing to the economy. [. . .] The Boeing worker, on the other hand, spends most of his income on his kids' school clothes, housing, [. . .] baseball tickets and other necessities, like an occasional fifth of Smirnov. He's solid. Yes, I know. Many of our young stock-option-millionaires do good things for our community. Bill Gates is rapidly creating his own Marshall Plan. He sets a good example. But on the whole, we have too many millionaires. Some 59,000 Puget Sound-area households have a net worth of at least \$1 million. Lesser Seattle's mission is clear. Be tough on millionaires. Shame them into spending more. Better yet, figure out a way to separate them from their millions.

— Emmett Watson, *Seattle Times*, 1999⁸⁶

Making Microsoft Bill Gates and Paul Allen, who founded Microsoft in 1975, agreed with *Time* and *Harper's*, not Watson. Friends since their teenage years, they were products of the Seattle that Boeing built. Gates traced his Seattle lineage to the 1880s; his parents were both graduates of UW, both products of a professional class of lawyers, bankers, and businessmen, and both rooted in the civic society of the Seattle area.⁸⁷ His father was an attorney who had found enough success as the region prospered to enroll Gates at the private Lakeside School and eventually Harvard University; it was crucial to the trajectory of Microsoft, Gates's biographers wrote, that he had “the upper-crust kid's professed disdain for mere lucre,” and hence took decisions that sought to make the company powerful, not just profitable.⁸⁸ Allen's family was financially comfortable enough for him to attend Lakeside too, and his father was the associate director of the libraries at UW.⁸⁹ It was among UW engineers in the young field of computer science, and sometimes even on the computers that UW bought, that Gates and Allen began working together in the late 1960s and early 1970s.⁹⁰

Gates and Allen founded Microsoft in Albuquerque, New Mexico, to supply software to Micro Instrumentation and Telemetry Systems (MITS), the company that put the first commercially viable personal computer, the Altair 8800, on sale in 1975.⁹¹ Their fundamental, enduring strategy was to write software at a time when other computer companies concentrated on hardware; their guiding vision was “a computer on every desk and in every home, running Microsoft software.”⁹² After the late 1970s, the BASIC software that Microsoft crammed onto the Altair became “the common denominator of microcomputer software.”⁹³ In 1981, IBM's Personal Computer, the PC, began shipping with MS-DOS, an operating system that Gates, in time, made “the foundation of his empire.”⁹⁴ Windows followed in 1985, and Windows 95 a decade later; as well as operating systems, the company cornered writing with Word, spreadsheets with Excel, and browsing with Internet Explorer. By 2001, the year Microsoft transitioned to a new operating system, MS-DOS was powering 400 million computers.⁹⁵

Microsoft had long since become synonymous with Seattle, as Boeing had before it. Leaving the New Mexico desert behind, the company and its 12 staff moved to Bellevue in early 1979, days after finishing their first year with more than \$1 million in sales.⁹⁶ Across Lake Washington from Seattle, Bellevue at the time “was still on the sleepy side of a transition from cow pastures and horse trails to edge-city suburbanville,” and though Allen missed home and Gates's parents wanted him closer by, much of Microsoft's move could be explained more by what Seattle lacked.⁹⁷ Compared to Silicon

Valley, Seattle had virtually no competition as a software company, and though attracting talent to the Pacific Northwest might be a challenge, employees would be easier to keep and cost far less, especially given depressed house prices.⁹⁸

Soon the Bellevue offices felt inadequate, and, in February 1986, Microsoft moved to Redmond, a place, the writer Emily Baillargeon Russin recalled, that “consisted of a tiny grid of pizza joints, a few gas stations, and a collection of even tinier strip malls; the rest was open farmland.”⁹⁹ Gates built a 400-acre campus—500 acres, eventually—that was carefully designed to ensure that workaholic employees would be isolated from any possible distractions. It was right off the freeway, for easy commuting, and sprouted cafeterias, sports facilities, and everything else that Softies, as the staff were known, needed to stay at work for longer.¹⁰⁰ “The social lives of Microsoft’s young programmers revolved around Microsoft,” Gates’s biographers wrote, “which meant their entire lives centered around what [one] consultant saw as ‘this domain that they have under control.’”¹⁰¹ For many, Gates included, Microsoft’s attraction was its separation from the real world.¹⁰² “[P]art of why Microsoft succeeds is that, for all its highly motivated drones, it’s really like being in college all over again,” Baillargeon Russin wrote.¹⁰³

Microsoft millionaires If Microsoft’s headquarters were akin to a college campus, its students were the wealthiest on Earth. Before its initial public offering (IPO) in March 1986, Microsoft had several hundred employees who held stock in the company; many became paper millionaires when the company went public.¹⁰⁴ But as Microsoft stock climbed over a hundredfold in the next decade, recruits who had tolerated relatively low salaries in exchange for stock options cashed in.¹⁰⁵ In 1992, one fifth of Microsoft’s 11,000 Redmond employees were millionaires, and a third of those were millionaires at least three times over.¹⁰⁶ By 2003, when the company replaced its option program with pure stock grants, it had minted 10,000 millionaires.¹⁰⁷ Although some were executives, many were rank-and-file software developers.¹⁰⁸ Only full-time Softies profited from the bonanza; as many as one third of Redmond campus workers were temporarily seconded from employment agencies and paid part-time, by the hour.¹⁰⁹ But for the fortunate, the money was life-changing.

Seattle had never seen this kind of concentrated wealth creation before—the \$8 billion of stock options that 8,000 Microsoft employees sold in 1999 was enough to pay all of the 99,000 workers that Boeing employed that year, one and a half times over—and it was unclear what would come of it.¹¹⁰ At first, Microsoft’s millionaires behaved with “extreme understatement,” one observer wrote, but they soon shook off their caution, as the *Washington Post* explained:

Greater Seattle went into a delirium of high-end consumption. Workmen invaded city neighborhoods, gutting and rebuilding thousands of old houses that offered views of water or mountains. In the eastern suburbs, monstrous new homes—Microsoft mansions—encircled lakes and marched into the foothills of the Cascades. Suddenly, there were waiting lists for yachts, Ferraris and Steinway pianos. Newly purchased horses far outnumbered stalls in local stables. Soaring new-car sales merged with 15 percent population growth to create traffic congestion that ranked among the worst in the nation. [. . .] The number of mental health counselors jumped by 55 percent.¹¹¹

Some Microsoft employees also became philanthropists, though they tended to support different causes to prior generations of the Seattle elite.¹¹² Often it was tricky to track how much they donated, though a common proxy was giving to United Way, a nonprofit that centralized workplace fundraising and distributed raised funds to a range of major charities. By the late 1990s, Seattle boasted the highest per-capita giving, and the second-highest total giving, to United Way among U.S. cities.¹¹³ Although Softies typically concentrated on the causes that were important to them personally, from political

campaigns to environmental activism, some trends did emerge: UW, for example, received \$284 million in donations from people associated with the company between 1990 and 2003.¹¹⁴

Some Microsoft money, however, reshaped Seattle in more conspicuous ways. While Gates focused on disease, gender equality, and other global challenges through the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, Allen, who kept equity and a board seat at Microsoft after he quit in 1983, believed that “it is important to try to help the community you have lived in.”¹¹⁵ Allen saved the Seattle Seahawks football team by buying it in 1997, paid for a statewide vote that unlocked public funding for most of the \$430 million it cost to construct a new stadium, and eventually won a Super Bowl.¹¹⁶ He spent \$250 million building what was eventually known as the Museum of Pop Culture at the base of the Space Needle, hiring the star architect Frank Gehry to design it to echo the look of electric guitars, in homage to Seattle native Jimi Hendrix.¹¹⁷ He refurbished old Seattle icons including Union Station and the Cinerama, and made major investments in biotechnology, including a \$100 million Allen Institute for Brain Science.¹¹⁸

For many observers, Allen’s commitment to Seattle was the mark of an enlightened billionaire, one who remembered where he came from.¹¹⁹ More skeptical onlookers feared “an emerging sense of the city as a vast personal playground that has become increasingly unsettling.”¹²⁰ Either way, Allen’s impact was profound, nowhere more so than in his reshaping of the South Lake Union district of town. (See **Exhibit 3**.) Foiled by public opposition in his initial plan to turn a dilapidated industrial area into a park, from the late 1990s Allen’s Vulcan Real Estate firm bought up land and used it to create an innovation district.¹²¹ By the time Allen died in 2018, South Lake Union had transformed Seattle—rather than its suburbs—into a thriving technology hub, supporting 59,000 jobs and generating \$551 million in tax revenues for the city.¹²² South Lake Union’s most important corporate resident was Amazon, and its founder, Jeff Bezos, had just supplanted Gates as the wealthiest person in the world.¹²³

Amazon

We fought the good fight, didn't we? Together we fought against alien invaders of our pristine Northwest. We wrote letters describing any light rainfall as a doomsday deluge. We publicized our mudslides. We promoted rudeness to visitors so they would leave and never come back. [. . .] But something went wrong. Prosperity killed our movement. We are victims of our own economic gluttony, corrupted by infidels of the Information Age. [. . .] We are up to our armpits in plutocrats.

— Emmett Watson, *Seattle Times*, 1999¹²⁴

Amazon arrives Amazon swept through the riverbed that Microsoft had helped to make. By 1994, almost one quarter of U.S. households had access to a computer, a number that hit 42% within four years; meanwhile, household Internet use rose from near-nothing to 26%.¹²⁵ Combined, personal computing and Internet access presaged a revolution in human society. A Princeton-trained electrical engineer and computer scientist, Bezos was one of many pioneers who realized that computing and the Internet would also revolutionize commerce. Assigned to investigate the Internet while working at D. E. Shaw, a New York hedge fund, Bezos saw in 1994 that online sales offered a unique opportunity for a middleman to profit, perhaps even through an “everything store.”¹²⁶ He started with books.¹²⁷

Despite Microsoft’s success, Bezos considered several alternatives before settling on Seattle for the headquarters of his company, including Portland, Oregon, and Boulder, Colorado.¹²⁸ But Seattle had everything he needed: available technical talent; a small statewide population, which would keep sales taxes low; a book distributor nearby, to shorten delivery times.¹²⁹ It also had buzz. Microsoft was going macro, Seattle-founded Starbucks was putting coffee shops on every street corner, Seattle-set *Frasier* was winning Emmy awards, while the Seattle-born rockers of Pearl Jam and Nirvana were topping the *Billboard* charts. “Everybody Else Is Moving There,” a *Newsweek* cover blared. “Should You?”¹³⁰ Bezos

and his wife, MacKenzie, decided that they should. One day in the summer of 1994, movers left their New York apartment with instructions only to drive West; the next, Bezos told them to head for Seattle.¹³¹ “I’m not sure what finally swayed him,” a friend recalled. “I’m not even sure if *he* knows.”¹³²

At first, Amazon appeared to be just another young Seattle company surfing the Internet wave. Network Commerce Inc., Freeinternet.com, HomeGrocer, MyLackey, Kozmo; the city was awash in e-commerce startups, and the flood of cash entering town fueled \$800 million in civic building, including a new public library and a new City Hall.¹³³ For its part, Amazon sold its first book in April 1995, raised its first venture capital a year later, and listed on the NASDAQ a year after that, at a valuation of \$438 million.¹³⁴ “Get Big Fast” was its motto, and it got big, fast: even as a widening product range grew revenues from \$148 million in 1997 to \$2.8 billion in 2000, it posted escalating losses that surpassed \$1.4 billion in 2000.¹³⁵ Few predicted that it would survive when the dotcom bubble burst; even Warren Buffett thought that its escape was “not at all obvious.”¹³⁶ Many of the other Seattle dotcoms collapsed, after all. From 2000 to 2003, Seattle lost 24,000 tech jobs, on top of the 50,000 layoffs that the aerospace industry endured from a recession and the 9/11 terrorist attacks.¹³⁷ Once again, Seattle had the worst unemployment in the U.S.; after violent anti-globalization protests greeted a World Trade Organization conference in 1999, even Boeing fled for Chicago.¹³⁸ One writer called Seattle “a city under siege.”¹³⁹

Amazon and Seattle survive Yet Amazon clung on. Bezos imposed cost discipline, demanded efficiency improvements in logistics, and hired experienced retail executives; Amazon borrowed brand loyalty principles from Costco, applied a manufacturing philosophy from Toyota to its fulfillment centers, and learned from Walmart to focus on delivering low prices for its customers.¹⁴⁰ Bezos also began to turn Amazon into an e-commerce platform, rather than a simple retailer, allowing third-party sellers to use its Marketplace feature from 2000, and laying the groundwork for Amazon Web Services (AWS), a suite of software and cloud computing products that emerged from its own attempts to build a digital infrastructure sufficient to cope with its sprawling physical footprint.¹⁴¹ Amazon turned its first profit at the end of 2001, when it had fewer than 8,000 employees.¹⁴² By the end of 2012, when it moved to South Lake Union, it had around 88,000 employees worldwide and revenues of \$61 billion.¹⁴³

In the intervening decade, Seattle recovered its credibility and dynamism as a technology center, in part because of the wider availability of venture capital specifically attuned to the community. In 1995, Tom Alberg, Paul Goodrich, Gerald Grinstein, and William Ruckelshaus formed Madrona, which raised \$2 billion in the two decades following its first fund in 1999, deploying almost all of it in the Pacific Northwest; Alberg, formerly a lead outside counsel for Boeing, was an Amazon angel investor and longtime board member.¹⁴⁴ Other Seattle firms growing at the same time included Maveron, which was co-founded by Starbucks CEO Howard Schultz and made its first investment in eBay, and Ignition Partners, formed by former Microsoft executives.¹⁴⁵ Often funded by investors whose expertise or cash could be traced to Microsoft and Amazon, several Seattle startups set course to prosper. Among them were Redfin, supported by Madrona and co-founded by a former head of personalization at Amazon, and Zillow, created by the founders of travel agency Expedia, which itself had originated at Microsoft.

After Amazon moved to South Lake Union, its ambitions sprawled. It had launched its Kindle reading tablet in 2007, turning it into a device maker; seven years later, it moved into smart speakers with the Echo, and millions of households began talking to a disembodied voice called Alexa.¹⁴⁶ It became a major player in streaming.¹⁴⁷ It turned itself into a membership organization not unlike Costco, through the Prime subscription service that gave customers free, rapid delivery for a fixed payment each year, and access to discount events like Prime Day, which was first held in 2015.¹⁴⁸ For more than a decade it tried to become a grocery titan in its own way, but it failed, so it simply bought Whole Foods for \$13.4 billion in 2017.¹⁴⁹ It became an airline, a healthcare provider, a robotics pioneer, and a film studio.¹⁵⁰ AWS was crucial: it earned only a small percentage of Amazon’s revenues but a

majority of its profits, and, despite rising competition from Microsoft's Azure, it dominated the cloud services that were increasingly essential to businesses and governments alike.¹⁵¹ In September 2018, its market capitalization crossed \$1 trillion, days after Apple first passed that threshold.¹⁵² (See **Exhibit 4**.) "You will live in Amazon's world, it says, and you will like it," one reporter wrote of the company.¹⁵³

Amazon's world Nowhere was more "Amazon's world" than Seattle. By 2018, the company had 647,500 full- and part-time employees worldwide, the majority in its fulfillment centers, but the 45,000 or so who worked in its Seattle offices represented its innovative, executive core.¹⁵⁴ Its Seattle headcount had tripled in five years and was still growing quickly; it paid every twelfth worker in the city, and many more were supported by its presence, around two for each Amazon employee in the estimates of some scholars, but five in the eyes of tech boosters.¹⁵⁵ The company occupied one fifth of all premium office space in the city, and owned or rented more office space than the next 40 biggest Seattle employers combined; its 8.1 million square feet of premises were by far the largest urban office campus in the U.S.¹⁵⁶ Employees were nonetheless still working in hallways.¹⁵⁷ The company had spent \$4 billion on real estate, and it estimated that it had generated \$38 billion in other investment.¹⁵⁸

Amazon's culture shaped the specifics of its downtown footprint. "You can work long, hard or smart," Bezos wrote in 1997, "but at Amazon.com you can't choose two out of three."¹⁵⁹ A couple of decades later, feedback remained competitive and unsparing; 80-hour weeks were the norm; executives "sought to manage out a certain percentage of its work force annually."¹⁶⁰ Some found the atmosphere intoxicating; others, destructive.¹⁶¹ Either way, the intensity of Amazon jobs shaped urban geography. More than 70% of its Seattle employees lived within city limits; one in five slept in the same ZIP code as their desk.¹⁶² One in five walked to work and most commuted without a car; public transportation struggled, despite South Lake Union receiving nearly \$700 million in new infrastructure, five sixths of it from public funds.¹⁶³ Amazon was causing retail stores everywhere to close, but in its hometown, retail sales grew 19% per year from 2010 to 2015.¹⁶⁴ House prices rose 47% in a decade; rents climbed 63% from 2010 to 2017.¹⁶⁵ Amazon even shifted demographics: its workers skewed so young and male that Seattle counted 120 single men under the age of 45 for every hundred women.¹⁶⁶

"Amazon's extraordinary growth has turned Seattle into the biggest company town in America," *Seattle Times* reporters concluded in August 2017, drawing an explicit and ominous comparison to the Jet City years.¹⁶⁷ The next month, Amazon announced that other U.S. cities could begin making proposals to host a second major campus, known as HQ2.¹⁶⁸ "[H]eads up, Other North American City: Amazon is about to detonate a prosperity bomb in your town," *Seattle Times* columnist Danny Westneat wrote.¹⁶⁹ "Your gain wasn't greeted by everyone in Seattle as our loss."¹⁷⁰ In time, 238 U.S. cities bid for HQ2; the company initially selected Arlington, Virginia, and an area of New York City, but quickly faced opposition in New York and abandoned its plans there.¹⁷¹ Yet Amazon's true HQ2 turned out to be Bellevue, where real estate availability and new transport links attracted a fresh influx of tech companies.¹⁷² City officials there welcomed up to 25,000 Amazon workers, roughly the same as were planned for the Arlington campus; rather than call Seattle its home, the company began to say that it had a "Puget Sound Headquarters."¹⁷³ Part of Amazon's reasoning was that its mere presence in Seattle had become increasingly controversial as the fallout from the "prosperity bomb" spread.

Contemporary Seattle

The problem with Watson's Lesser Seattle was twofold. One, most of his readers didn't really believe in it. Two, neither did Watson. It was a pose, a posture, a way to give his column the salty taste of clam nectar. Watson actually loved the energy of the bustling boomtown, as he confessed to me over lunch one day in Pioneer Square during the era of dot-comania. I felt for a moment as if I had glimpsed the man behind Oz's curtain. The lovable

curmudgeon turned out to be a sweet old Chamber of Commerce-lovin' teddy bear. [. . .] In the civic arena, Lesser Seattle is barely a memory. [. . .] [T]he new vision is a kind of Manhattanization of the city. Density is good, in and of itself. Growth is inevitable – in fact, encouraged. [. . .] The small, livable, sensible, sustainable city we once purported to love is dead. Lesser Seattle is a corpse rotting in the rain.

– Knute Berger, *Seattle Weekly*, 2006¹⁷⁴

A New Middle Class?

Seattle's wealth By early 2026, the basis of Seattle's rocketing prosperity had shifted from physical manufacturing to the products of knowledge work. Microsoft and Amazon were both multi-trillion-dollar companies by market valuation: in their most recent financial statements, Microsoft reported \$305 billion in annual revenues and a net income of \$119 billion, while Amazon's \$716 billion in earnings made it the largest company in the U.S. by revenue, outstripping Walmart.¹⁷⁵ All the major tech companies had offices in town, and they rubbed shoulders with at least 20 software unicorns, startups valued over \$1 billion.¹⁷⁶ Roughly one in seven Seattle employees worked in tech, about the same proportion as San Jose, home of Silicon Valley.¹⁷⁷ Applications to UW's Paul G. Allen School of Computer Science & Engineering rose from 873 in 2010 to 7,587 in 2022, making computer science the most popular major on campus, far more so than anything offered at the William E. Boeing Department of Aeronautics & Astronautics.¹⁷⁸ Even if Boeing's factories still paid 50,000 workers in a bad year, its headquarters having left town in 2001, Seattle's public image had turned from analog to digital.¹⁷⁹

Seattle had become one of the wealthiest and most educated cities in the U.S. Full-time, year-round workers in Seattle earned more than their peers in almost every major city in the country.¹⁸⁰ In 2024, Seattle's median household income was \$118,745, 37% more than the national norm; in 2000, when its population had been a third smaller, its median household had earned \$45,736.¹⁸¹ Tech worker earnings were the highest among King County professionals, at a median wage of \$163,600, and they had grown faster in the previous decade than legal or managerial salaries.¹⁸² (Most Amazon software engineers earned more than that median, and managers much more.)¹⁸³ Analysts found that Seattle had around 54,200 millionaires and 11 billionaires, both more than Boston but fewer than six other major cities.¹⁸⁴ One third of Americans had a college degree, and 14% had a graduate or professional degree, but in Seattle the figures were 70% and 32%, respectively.¹⁸⁵ Proportionally fewer Seattleites owned their homes than Americans in general, but 90% of those who did owned homes worth more than \$500,000, and 45% owned homes worth more than \$1 million, compared to 8% nationwide.¹⁸⁶ King County babies born in the early 2020s could expect to live six years longer than the typical American infant.¹⁸⁷

Seattle's inequality Yet Seattle's prosperity was unequally shared. Although Seattle did not rank among the most unequal U.S. metropolitan areas by conventional income inequality measures (see **Exhibit 5**), it experienced a pronounced structural shift in how income was distributed. Across most U.S. states, labor's share of income declined steadily from the mid-1970s onward (see **Exhibit 6**). In Washington State, that decline was steeper than in many parts of the country, suggesting that the region's growth model disproportionately favored capital, equity holders, and high-skilled earners.

Within that structural context, disparities in Seattle widened. From 2019 to 2023, the average household income of the highest-earning twentieth of Seattleites grew by a quarter, from \$596,000 to \$744,000, not including unrealized capital gains from stocks.¹⁸⁸ Seattle's top 20% saw earnings rise 23%, from \$357,800 to \$439,900; incomes for the lowest-earning quintile rose only 10%, from \$19,200 to \$21,100.¹⁸⁹ Poverty rates were lower than national and statewide averages, but climbing; in 2024, 9.4% of Seattleites lived below the federal poverty line, defined as income of \$15,060 for an individual or

\$31,200 for a family of four.¹⁹⁰ Economic disparities shaped future possibilities, too. “In the past decade,” a reporter wrote of Seattle’s schools in 2023, “the district’s gap in academic outcomes between Black and white students grew to one of the widest in the country.”¹⁹¹ “[T]he rising tide hasn’t lifted all boats,” concluded *Seattle Times* columnist Gene Balk. “It seems to have just lifted the yachts.”¹⁹²

Growing inequality was compounded by Seattle’s high cost of living. Statistics compiled in the first quarter of 2022 found that Seattle was the ninth-most expensive city in the U.S., with prices 51% higher than national averages; by 2024, it had fallen to eleventh, with costs still 45% higher than U.S. norms.¹⁹³ Strangely, Seattle was the most expensive place in the country for men to get a haircut, but much more importantly it was also one of the most expensive places to buy or rent a place to live, at more than double typical levels on standard housing indices.¹⁹⁴ By 2024, the median price of a starter home was \$535,000, for which the monthly mortgage payment would be \$4,334 per month with a 3.5% down payment.¹⁹⁵ “Affordable” housing was defined as housing that cost no more than 30% of a resident’s income: the median Seattle starter home required a salary of \$173,378 – far more than the city’s median income.¹⁹⁶ Seattle housing costs were already high in 2010, before Amazon began growing in earnest: from then through 2024, the average price of a single-family home rose from \$444,000 to \$926,000, a 109% rise that was higher than the 91% rise in the median sales price of all U.S. housing.¹⁹⁷ The fair market rent of a two-bedroom apartment in Seattle climbed from \$1,056 to \$2,645 across the same period; U.S. rents in general rose only 65%.¹⁹⁸ Before Seattle changed its zoning laws in 2025, three quarters of residential land in the city was reserved for single-family homes, preventing construction of duplexes, triplexes, and denser forms of housing accommodating multiple families on one lot.¹⁹⁹

Housing inflation sometimes had dire consequences. (See **Exhibit 7**.) Seattleites who worked as firefighters, nurses, and teachers were forced to move to the suburbs.²⁰⁰ Gentrification consumed entire neighborhoods; over several decades, the proportion of Black residents in the Central District area of town fell from 80% to 10%.²⁰¹ Eviction cases in King County rose from 5,223 in 2013 to 8,732 in 2025, overloading courts and swamping lawyers.²⁰² King County already had the third largest homeless population behind New York and Los Angeles by 2017, with 11,643 people unhoused.²⁰³ By 2024, 16,868 people were unhoused, and 58% of them were unsheltered, living in tents, parked cars, or simply outdoors.²⁰⁴ About 66% qualified as chronically homeless; 47% of all unhoused adults had a substance use disorder, and 34% had a serious mental illness.²⁰⁵ Many unhoused people preferred not to use shelters; around 1,000 shelter beds sat unused.²⁰⁶

Had Amazon created a new middle class, or destroyed an older one? In 2026, surveys found that roughly two thirds of U.S. voters believed that “a middle-class lifestyle is out of reach for most people,” and for many Seattleites, that ideal status in life, so attainable in the Boeing years, seemed still more painfully difficult.²⁰⁷ Standard statistical constructs defined a middle-class household as having an income of between two-thirds and double the national median; in 2022, a U.S. family of four needed to earn \$67,819 to \$203,458 to qualify.²⁰⁸ On that definition, adjusted for living costs, 51% of Seattle-area residents qualified as “middle income,” the same as the rest of the U.S.; 22% were “lower income” and 27% were “upper income.”²⁰⁹ According to Brookings, which defined the middle class as the middle 60% of earners, only 58% of the Seattle-area middle-class – earning \$33,618 to \$171,449 in 2023 – could afford “basic necessities” like childcare and clothes.²¹⁰ For many people, being “middle class” was also not reducible to numbers on a paycheck; it was a feeling of security, of predictability.²¹¹ In Seattle, that sense often felt distant. Politically, the question was who should be responsible for restoring it.

How to Fix Seattle

What I’ve tried to do as mayor is to say, without ambiguity, that we value their jobs. We also believe in a culture of accountability.

— Bruce Harrell, Mayor of Seattle, 2025²¹²

Seattle should be a city where you can busk at Pike Place Market and afford to live here. What we lose when it becomes this kind of pressure cooker where you have to have a tech job in order to survive is so profound, right? It becomes a city that's more sterile. It becomes a city that's more alienated. We lose that community.

— Katie Wilson, mayoral candidate, 2025²¹³

Amazon and its city As Amazon's visibility grew, Seattle divided into political camps. In 2013, a socialist candidate for city council, Kshama Sawant, squeaked a victory in a citywide election, on a platform of taxing the rich; investing in housing, transit, and education; and a \$15-an-hour minimum wage.²¹⁴ Much of Sawant's rhetoric drew on her own history as the wife of a Microsoft software engineer and as an Occupy Wall Street activist—she damned “highway robbers on Wall Street” and accused Boeing of “economic terrorism” for threatening to leave town—but she also voiced increasingly common concerns.²¹⁵ “The city has made glittering fortunes for the super wealthy and for the major corporations that dominate Seattle's landscape,” she said in her inauguration speech. “At the same time, the lives of working people, the unemployed, and the poor grow more difficult by the day. The cost of housing skyrockets, and education and healthcare become inaccessible.”²¹⁶ She was elected three more times; in her decade in office, moderate figures increasingly made similar arguments.²¹⁷

For tech leaders on the other side of the debate, such attacks were not only counterproductive but a threat to Seattle's future prosperity. One of the most eloquent was Alberg, whose civic stature recalled the quiet power of the Boeing chieftains.²¹⁸ Alberg, who described Watson's Lesser Seattle fiction as “elitist,” believed that Seattle had succeeded through the operation of a flywheel not unlike the one that Amazon itself saw at the core of its business (see **Exhibit 8**). “As more talented people move to Seattle,” he wrote, “more innovations give rise to new companies, which attract more creative people, and the flywheel accelerates.”²¹⁹ Alberg was not blind to the perils of prosperity, but insisted that the best chance of keeping the flywheel turning came when “city governments and tech companies work together on solutions—in ways that go beyond lip service and advisory committees.”²²⁰ He offered an example with his founding, in 2015, of Challenge Seattle, a forum in which the CEOs of Costco, the Gates Foundation, Microsoft, Nordstrom, Starbucks, Zillow, and other groups worked on issues like traffic congestion.²²¹ (Amazon was initially a member, but left after a few years.)²²² Alberg saw efforts to tax the most successful tech companies as evidence that elected officials were “increasingly radicalized,” even “hostile” to firms that had made Seattle what it had become.²²³

Policy debates After 2016, much of the debate played out in a battle of corporate philanthropy and municipal tax policy. Facing pressure from Sawant, Amazon, which the *Seattle Times* wrote had long been “a small-time donor” in “a city noted for its big-time philanthropy,” began to increase its community spending, focusing especially on housing.²²⁴ In 2016, it worked with Mary's Place, a local charity, to turn a Travelodge hotel it owned into a homeless shelter, then built a dedicated, eight-floor shelter into a building it opened in South Lake Union four years later.²²⁵ In 2021, Amazon announced the creation of a \$2 billion Housing Equity Fund to invest in affordable housing in Seattle and elsewhere, and three years later added a further \$1.4 billion; much of its work—in the form of loans and grants—preserved existing housing so that it could not be redeveloped and rented at a higher price, and primarily targeted workers earning 50% to 80% of the local median income.²²⁶

Even so, Seattle elected officials asked for more. Seattle was limited in its ability to raise revenue from tech companies and their employees; the city levied property taxes, sales taxes, “business and occupation” taxes on gross receipts, and other taxes, but personal income taxes and standard corporate taxes had been considered unconstitutional in Washington since the 1930s.²²⁷ In 2017, when Amazon's state and local taxes totaled about \$250 million, a Sawant proposal for an income tax on individuals

earning over \$250,000 passed the city council, but faltered in court.²²⁸ The following year, when Amazon's rising profits gave it a state and local tax bill of \$297 million, the council unanimously passed an "Employee Hours Tax," charging major companies \$275 per employee to fund housing.²²⁹ Furious, Bezos capped Amazon's Seattle headcount, accelerated the Bellevue move, and halted construction projects.²³⁰ "What company," asked Andy Jassy, the AWS CEO who would become CEO of the whole firm in 2021, "is going to want to start—or move to or grow in—a city that penalizes them for hiring full-time employees?"²³¹ Facing union as well as corporate opposition, the council quickly repealed the tax.²³² Amazon then raised its spending on Seattle politics tenfold, donating \$1.5 million in 2019 to friendly council candidates backed by the Chamber of Commerce.²³³ Sawant was reelected anyway.²³⁴

In 2020, Seattle politicians led by Councilmember Teresa Mosqueda took a more accommodating approach, the threat of Sawant's activism lurking behind them.²³⁵ Collaborating with tech companies including Expedia, Mosqueda passed the JumpStart tax, which Westneat called a "boss tax" as opposed to the "head tax" in the 2018 law.²³⁶ JumpStart solely targeted businesses with payrolls of more than \$7 million—exempting many small businesses—and taxed them 0.7% to 2.4% of each salary they paid over \$150,000.²³⁷ The following year, the council required that 62% of the proceeds be spent on affordable housing, allotting the rest to economic development, climate resilience, and administrative costs.²³⁸ JumpStart attracted few protests from the companies subject to it, even the ten that paid about 70% of its receipts.²³⁹ It was also so successful fiscally, raising more than analysts projected each year, that the council began relying on the surplus to balance the city's overall budget.²⁴⁰ Seattle's total tax receipts rose from \$851 million in 2006 to \$2.5 billion in 2024 (see **Exhibit 9**).²⁴¹

Even JumpStart made little dent in the housing crisis, however. In February 2023, voters therefore approved the creation of the Seattle Social Housing Developer (SSHD), which would provide publicly owned housing to residents earning between 50% and 120% of the local median wage, and charging them rent of no more than 30% of their income.²⁴² (Nonprofits and other city offices sought to provide housing for lower-income residents.)²⁴³ Two years later, in a special election held in February 2025, voters were asked to decide how best to fund the SSHD.²⁴⁴ Proposition 1A, which was placed on the ballot after a signature campaign, intended to generate \$50 million a year to fund 2,000 homes: it proposed a new tax on "excess compensation" modeled on JumpStart, in which companies would pay 5% on the payroll expenses of employees earning more than \$1 million, including stock and bonuses.²⁴⁵ Proposition 1B was added to the ballot by the city council as an alternative, and had the support of Mayor Bruce Harrell, the Chamber of Commerce, and firms including Amazon.²⁴⁶ It intended to use \$10 million per year of existing JumpStart funding and limit the SSHD to offering housing to residents earning 80% to 120% of the mean.²⁴⁷ Proposition 1A won in a landslide, with 63% of the vote.²⁴⁸

Harrell's effective defeat on the issue convinced Katie Wilson, a socialist and transit activist who had helped to pass JumpStart and Proposition 1A but had no prior electoral or governing experience, to mount a challenge against him for the mayoralty that fall.²⁴⁹ For many Seattleites, Wilson appeared to represent their own experience: she was married with a young daughter, earned \$73,000 per year running a nonprofit, and could not afford childcare without parental support.²⁵⁰ Among her proposals were a local capital gains tax, a \$1 billion bond issue to support housing construction, and a plan to protect renters like herself.²⁵¹ She won by 2,011 votes, a margin of 0.73%.²⁵² But by the time Wilson took office, in January 2026, Seattle's prospects seemed to be darkening once more.

Perils and promise of AI In 2025, the Puget Sound area suffered an overall decrease in jobs for the first time since 2009, the COVID-19 pandemic aside.²⁵³ Rents were down, though only by a handful of dollars per month; office lease costs were down, too; homes were taking longer to sell.²⁵⁴ Even though Amazon and Microsoft had required its workers to return to their Seattle offices after pandemic remote work, retail spending around their campuses had fallen as much as 7% in a year, and

restaurants downtown were closing twice as quickly as usual.²⁵⁵ Falling payroll and sales tax receipts had opened up a budget deficit in city accounts of more than \$100 million.²⁵⁶ “This is kind of the scariest time economically for the Seattle region since the Great Recession in 2009,” a local expert said.²⁵⁷

Behind Seattle’s slump lay a reconfiguration in the tech world as AI began to take hold. Despite its escalating share price, Amazon cut 14,000 corporate jobs globally in October 2025, including over 2,000 in Washington, mostly recruiters, analysts, and managers.²⁵⁸ It slashed another 16,000 the following January, this time laying off at least 1,400 staff in Seattle and 600 in Bellevue.²⁵⁹ Microsoft fired about 3,200 Washington employees in 2025, and there were also cuts at Meta, Salesforce, and Expedia.²⁶⁰ For tech workers, AI posed a dual threat. Companies developing AI products sought to use those products, especially to automate coding tasks previously taken on by junior developers.²⁶¹ More immediately, firms needed to free up cash to spend on computing infrastructure like data centers. Amazon’s corporate cuts came in the context of a \$200 billion splurge on capital expenditure in 2026, as it tried to overcome its slow start on AI and maintain AWS’s dominant position against Microsoft and Google.²⁶² “I don’t know if there’s ever been a time in the history of Amazon, or maybe business in general, with the technology transformation happening right now, where it’s important to be lean,” Jassy said. “It’s important to be flat, and it’s important to move fast. And that’s what we’re going to do.”²⁶³

Given that tech companies comprised 30% of the Seattle-area economy, anxiety inevitably and understandably grew.²⁶⁴ “To paraphrase the old saying about Boeing,” one journalist wrote, “when Big Tech sneezes, Seattle catches cold.”²⁶⁵ Reporters drew explicit comparisons to Boeing layoffs, and even to the infamous billboard of 1971.²⁶⁶ “It’s the awkward thing about the affordability debate,” Westneat wrote. “Nothing makes a city cheaper faster than an economic bust.”²⁶⁷ Although skepticism reigned, some observers remained optimistic. Tech companies had suffered before, after all, and “each time, Big Tech didn’t just recover,” one reporter noted, “it got much, *much* bigger.”²⁶⁸

In the first eight months of 2025, Seattle startups received double the venture capital funding they had won in the first eight months of 2024, and investors suggested that the city was poised to benefit from advances associated with AI.²⁶⁹ “This is Seattle’s generational opportunity,” one entrepreneur said. “We have the talent. We have the tech. Now we need to move louder, faster, and bolder.”²⁷⁰ Some investors maintained that Seattle’s concentration of engineers, cloud infrastructure, and experienced founders positioned it well for the AI era. Madrona managing director Matt McIlwain contended that thriving technology hubs combine access to ideas, skilled people, and are associated with sustained experimentation, enabling entrepreneurs and firms to learn faster.²⁷¹ By that logic, Seattle’s dense network of companies and talent could once again prove an advantage.

What future for Seattle? As Wilson’s four-year term began, the future of Seattle was as uncertain as it had been in years. On the campaign trail, she had struck a cautious balance when talking about the tech sector, reassuring Amazon and other companies that she sought a working relationship with them while warning residents that they could not assume that they would always be able to carry on “blithely riding the tech wave.”²⁷² In her first major speech as mayor, given as state lawmakers debated imposing an income tax on earnings over \$1 million, Wilson told business leaders that she valued the talent they attracted, the taxes they paid, and the donations they gave, and added that she knew that affordability was a problem for them, too.²⁷³ “We cannot be a great place to grow if families are priced out of the city,” she said, inviting employers to stay at the negotiating table, “even if the work can be difficult.”²⁷⁴

Decades earlier, Emmett Watson had warned that Seattle risked turning into a Rust Belt town, its best days receding ever further back in its history.²⁷⁵ Wilson, for her part, insisted that Seattle could be a “world-class city that we can all be proud of,” one that was both innovative and affordable.²⁷⁶ Should

Seattle continue to rely on the growth of its technology giants, even if that growth intensified inequality? Or should it impose new constraints and taxes, risking slower expansion in pursuit of broader inclusion? Could the city reconcile progress and equity, or would one inevitably come at the expense of the other?

Exhibit 1 Demographics of Seattle, 1860-2024

Census Year	Seattle Population	% Change	Seattle Metro. Area Population	% Change
1860	188			
1870	1,107	489%		
1880	3,533	219%		
1890	42,837	1113%		
1900	80,671	88%		
1910	237,194	194%		
1920	315,312	33%		
1930	365,583	16%		
1940	368,302	1%		
1950	467,591	27%		
1960	557,087	19%		
1970	530,831	-5%	1,836,949	
1980	493,846	-7%	2,093,285	14%
1990	516,259	5%	2,578,807	23%
2000	563,374	9%	3,052,698	18%
2010	608,660	8%	3,449,355	13%
2020	737,015	21%	4,027,949	17%
2024	780,995	6%	4,145,494	3%

Source: Compiled by casewriters from Seattle Municipal Archives, "Quick Information," <https://bit.ly/4saCYY7>; U.S. Census, "QuickFacts: Seattle city, Washington," <https://bit.ly/4ul7e3S>; U.S. Census retrieved from Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis (FRED); all accessed March 2026.

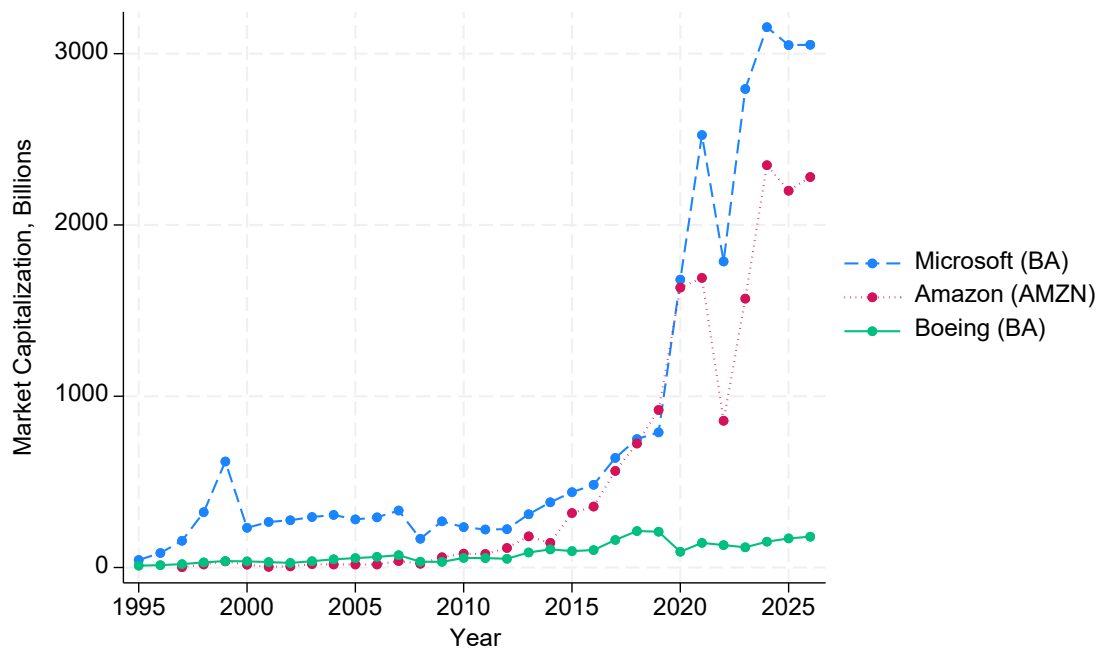
Note: Metro. = Metropolitan. The Seattle Metropolitan Area included King, Pierce, and Snohomish Counties, the three main counties of and around Seattle, including the cities of Tacoma, Redmond, and Bellevue. 2024 figures were estimates.

Exhibit 2 Seattle Billboard, 1971

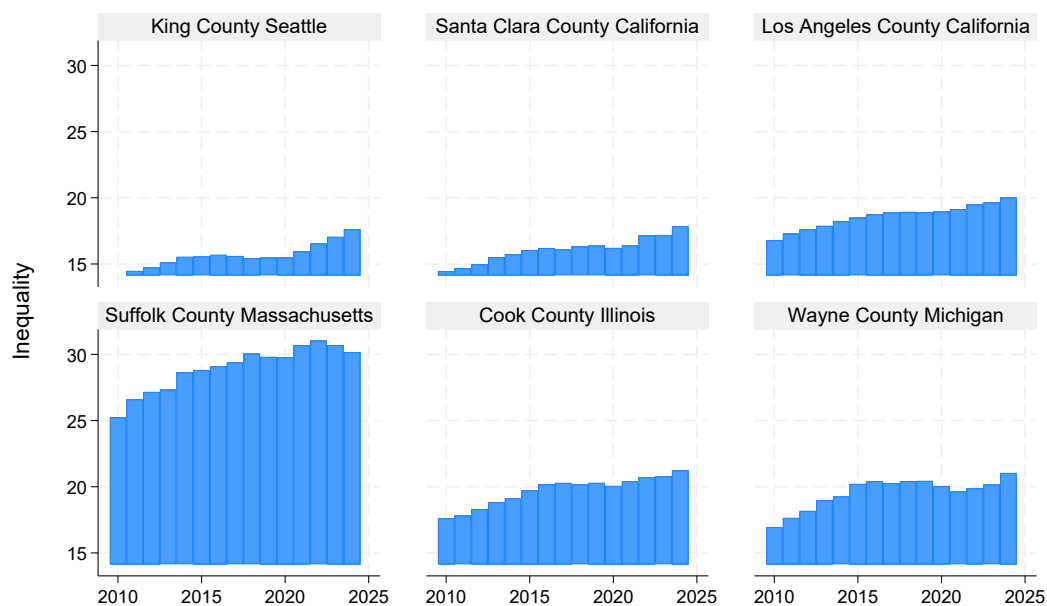
Source: Greg Gilbert / The Seattle Times via Alan J. Stein, "Boeing Bust (1969-1971)," HistoryLink, December 16, 2019, <https://bit.ly/4lIH3WL>, accessed February 2026.

Exhibit 3 South Lake Union, 2025

Source: Zoshua Colah, "City skyline under a beautiful sunset," February 2025, used under the Unsplash License. <https://bit.ly/3NsKqP8>, accessed March 2026.

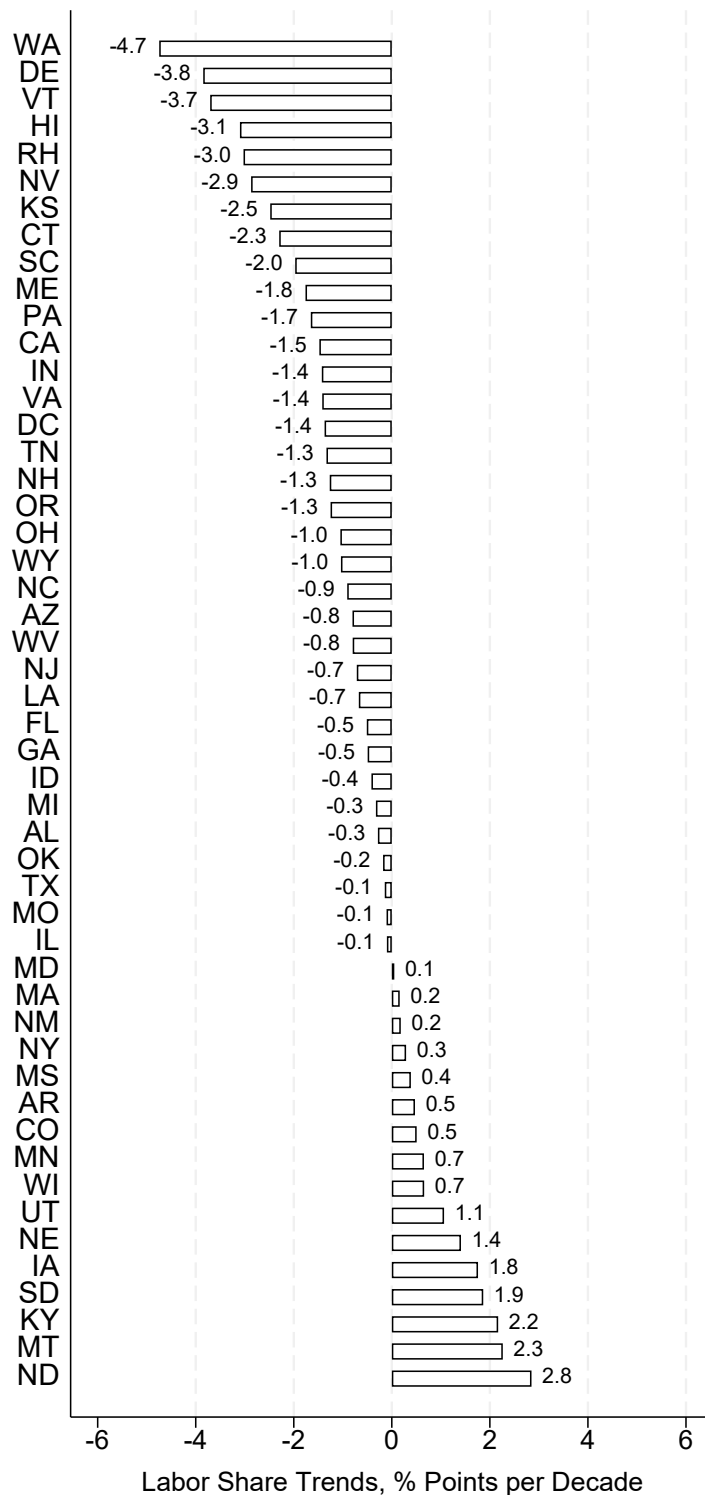
Exhibit 4 Market Capitalizations of Microsoft, Amazon, and Boeing, 1995-2026, USD

Source: Created by casewriters with from S&P Capital IQ, a division of S&P Global Inc.

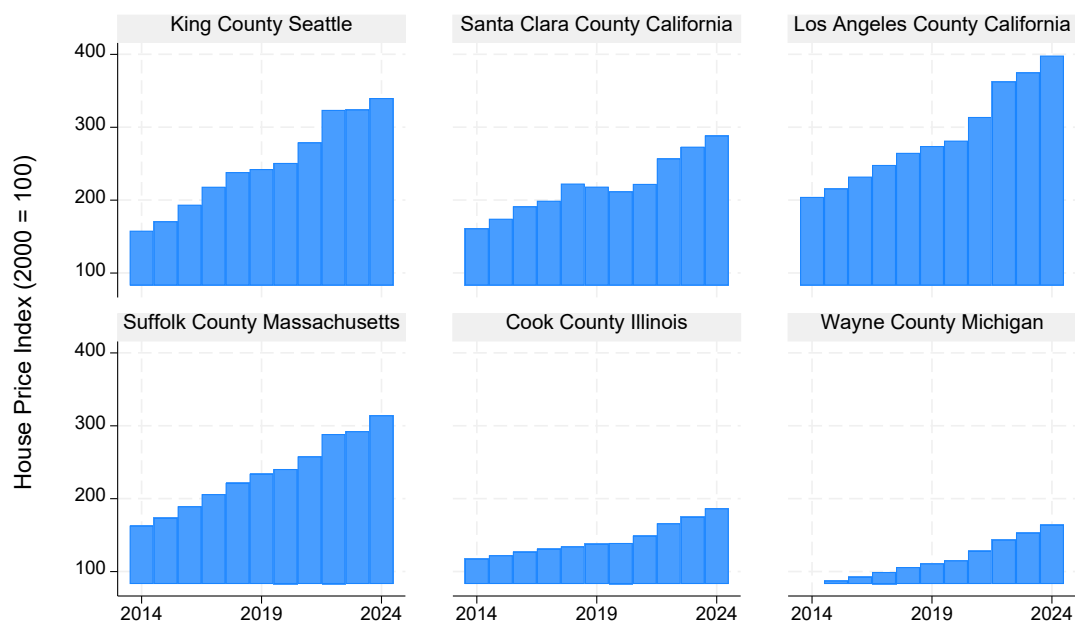
Exhibit 5 Income Inequality in the Seattle Area Relative to Other Counties, 2010-2024

Source: Created by casewriters with from the U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, <https://data.census.gov/>; Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis (FRED), <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/>; both accessed March 2026.

Note: Inequality measures the ratio between the mean income of the top 20% and the mean income of the bottom 20%.

Exhibit 6 The Labor Share in U.S. States, 1975–2012

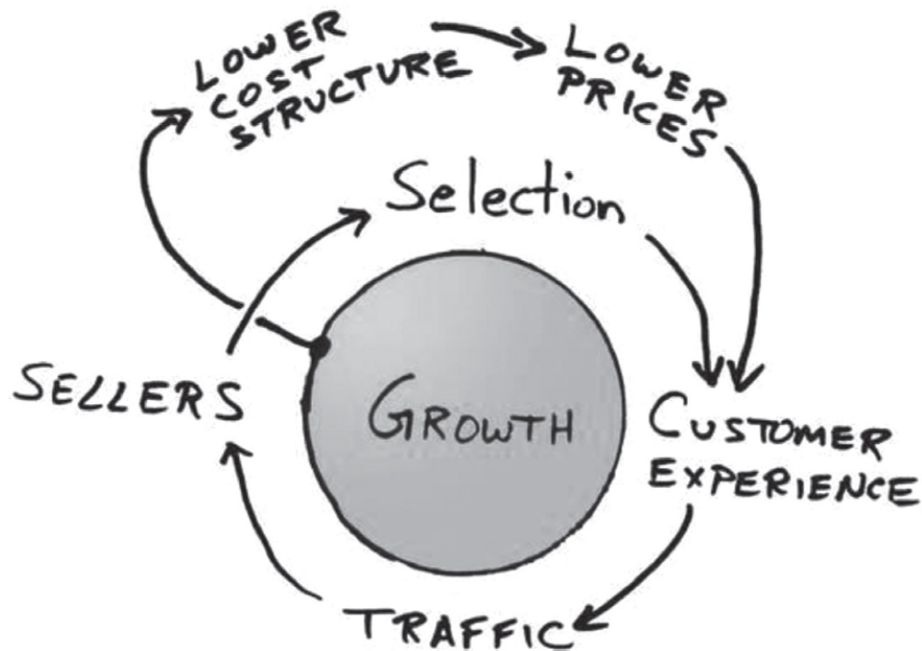
Source: Adapted from data in Loukas Karabarbounis and Brent Neiman, "The Global Decline of the Labor Share," *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, Vol. 29, No. 1 (February 2014): 61–103, p. 72, Fig IV.

Exhibit 7 House Price Growth in the Seattle Area Relative to Other Counties, 2014-2024

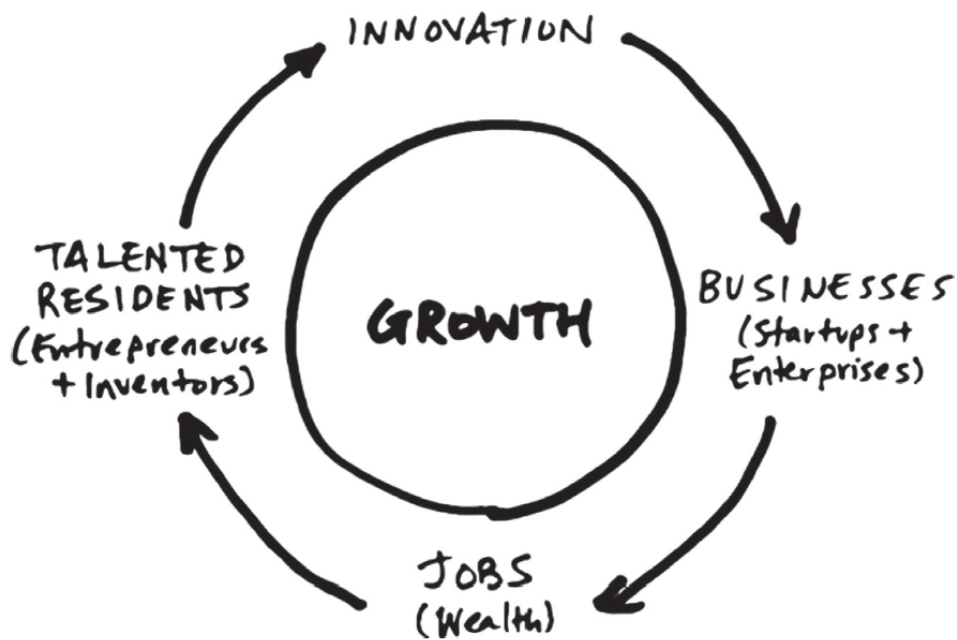
Source: Created by casewriters with from the Federal Housing Finance Agency (FHFA), All-Transactions House Price Index by county, via the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis (FRED), <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/>, accessed March 2026.

Exhibit 8 Flywheels

1) Amazon



2) Seattle



Source: Tom Alberg, *Flywheels: How Cities Are Creating Their Own Futures* (New York: Columbia Business School Publishing, 2021), pp. 32-33.

Exhibit 9 City of Seattle Sources of Tax Revenue, 2005-2024 (USD Thousands)

Year	Property Taxes	Sales Taxes	Business Taxes	Excise Taxes	Other Taxes	Total Taxes
2006	318,366	155,311	311,015	58,572	8,103	851,367
2007	359,651	171,846	332,238	76,918	16,589	957,242
2008	368,362	171,917	332,779	36,091	25,395	934,544
2009	397,041	150,515	329,572	27,710	32,449	927,287
2010	391,692	146,970	331,570	28,815	34,594	933,641
2011	397,439	158,582	339,703	35,203	42,254	973,181
2012	420,763	169,681	358,931	54,637	44,352	1,048,364
2013	423,928	181,171	408,913	61,525	11,240	1,086,777
2014	431,458	199,735	431,437	65,364	16,770	1,144,764
2015	420,691	239,189	454,086	101,098	17,733	1,232,797
2016	542,854	263,285	482,850	114,627	19,009	1,422,625
2017	582,622	280,963	516,881	115,674	22,032	1,518,172
2018	597,949	306,587	539,906	139,347	23,601	1,607,390
2019	640,075	324,302	579,312	166,349	33,708	1,743,746
2020	697,753	287,486	479,870	126,086	28,257	1,619,452
2021	707,382	343,317	816,861	143,424	51,111	2,062,095
2022	714,642	389,893	918,872	130,697	59,773	2,213,877
2023	782,897	399,651	973,816	85,208	65,226	2,306,798
2024	887,906	399,538	1,041,208	105,115	72,900	2,506,667

Source: Compiled by casewriters with data from City of Seattle, "Comprehensive Annual Financial Report For the Fiscal Year Ended December 31, 2015," p. 270, <https://bit.ly/4kXHfv9>; City of Seattle, "Annual Comprehensive Financial Report For the Year Ended December 31, 2024," p. 282, <https://bit.ly/4kSifp4>; both accessed February 2026.

Note: JumpStart taxes came into force on January 1, 2021, and are listed under business taxes.

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